

General Education Reflection

General education courses are intended to create well-rounded students by introducing knowledge and experience in other fields. This experience is intended to allow students to maintain breadth in their academic and professional lives. These courses are a critical part of engineering education because they allow engineers to broaden their problem-solving perspectives and innovate with inspiration from outside their field. This is no different within Cyber Security Engineering at Iowa State, based on my experience.

As a winter course, I took Russia Today, a course on the recent history of the USSR and Russia. One of the most impactful experiences I gained from this class was seeing how some people live day to day in the twenty-first century. One film in the course highlighted elderly women living on small homesteads in very poor conditions. Gaining insight into these individuals' lives reminds me that when problem-solving, my experience is unique and not that of everyone else, hence the inherent importance of considering alternatives.

Beyond breadth of perspectives, understanding the rationale for decisions and where users' experiences stem from is critical. Introduction to Psychology taught me to better analyze the source of users' emotions, both positive and negative. As an engineer, this allows me to innovate by creating solutions that are best tailored to users. User-centric design is something I am very passionate about, and something I believe we, as engineers, should prioritize in our work. A foundational education in psychology only furthers my passion for this.

Deeper knowledge of global experiences and societal reasoning from these courses allows me to be a stronger engineer. Without these courses, I'm sure I would still be a good engineer, but I wouldn't be able to be a great engineer, which is what I strive to be. I enjoyed these general education courses, as well as many others I took, and I'd recommend that any aspiring engineer take a wide variety of courses.